

Q.2b (15 marks): Durkheim's idea of sacred and profane provides an alternative understanding of religion

How does Durkheim's idea of sacred and profane provides an alternative to secularization thesis. (15 marks)

Durkheim while presenting his theory of religion proposed the idea of sacred and profane.

The secularization hypothesis suggests that as society advances and modernises, role of religion in society would decline and will be replaced by science.

Durkheim challenges this approach by suggesting that religion will survive as long as society survives because for Durkheim religion is nothing but society worshipping itself.

He suggests that old gods are dead and new Gods are arriving.

He further states that over time science may become the new religion.

Durkheim defines religion as a unified system of beliefs and practices related to sacred things i.e. things that are set apart and forbidden, which unite a moral community called church, all those who adhere to it.

Thus for Durkheim religion is not about supernatural but it is society worshipping itself and it stabilises society.

Sacred object is not about holy or pure but about any object that has a collective consciousness attached to it.

Whereas profane are those day to day mundane objects having no collective belief.

As per Durkheim, anything can become sacred if it has some collective belief. The belief in sacred objects unites society, creates collective effervescence and brings solidarity and integration.

Since humans are social animals, and want to live in society, this collective belief will last as long as society ~~last~~ persists.

Therefore, despite secularisation, members in society will continue to bestow their collective belief in certain sacred objects. These objects might change and over time science may emerge as the new sacred.

Thus, Durkheim's by the idea of sacred and profane presents an alternative view to persistence of religion despite secularisation.